

“there is only a **question of time**
... may we not agree that **the**
sooner the better?”

PRESIDENT LINCOLN, IN HIS MESSAGE TO CONGRESS, DECEMBER 6, 1864

The implications

In practical terms, the implementation of the measure still had to play out. Emancipated, or freed, slaves were no longer in legal bondage, but most of them still had to earn a living tilling the lands on which they had formerly worked, and their rights had to be won and protected. Equal civil rights for Black people would be a long time coming and the fight continued into the next century.

In the meantime, the thousands of emancipated people who poured onto the nation's streets to celebrate the passing of the amendment experienced personally an important milestone. The United States had changed decisively and they were no longer regarded as property. Still they looked forward to the day when they could vote and live among whites with true equality.